

A Question of Trust

Class 10 CBSE • Footprints Without Feet • Victor Canning

Detailed Exam-Oriented Solutions

Complete NCERT exercise solutions, character sketches, vocabulary, important quotations, extracts, very-short/short/long answers, value-based and competency-based questions, plus MCQs.

1. Chapter Information

Title	A Question of Trust
Author	Victor Canning
Genre	Crime / mystery short story
Main Characters	Horace Danby, the young woman posing as the lady of the house, Sherry

2. Character Sketches

Horace Danby

A fifty-year-old locksmith who appears respectable but secretly commits one burglary each year to finance his collection of rare and expensive books. He is careful, methodical and knowledgeable about locks, yet he is ultimately deceived by a clever female thief.

The Young Woman

A confident and intelligent thief who pretends to be the lady of Shotover Grange. She manipulates Horace by appearing calm and familiar with the house. She persuades him to open the safe and then leaves with the jewels, while Horace is later arrested.

Sherry

The dog at the house. His presence helps the woman appear to belong to the household and supports her deception.

3. Important Words & Meanings

respectable	considered socially proper or decent
hay fever	an allergic condition often caused by pollen
agent	a person who acts for another
rare	uncommon or difficult to find
meticulous	very careful and precise
safe	a strong locked box or cabinet for valuables
burglar	a person who enters a building illegally to steal
ornaments	decorative objects
handkerchief	a small cloth used for wiping the face or nose
culprit	the person responsible for a crime
fingerprints	unique patterns on fingertips used for identification

4. Important Quotations / Lines

“Everyone thought that Horace Danby was a good, honest citizen.”

Significance: This introduces the contrast between Horace’s respectable public image and his secret criminal activity.

“He loved rare, expensive books.”

Significance: His passion explains why he commits burglaries despite otherwise living an ordinary life.

“I’ll let you go, if you’ll do what I tell you.”

Significance: The woman uses apparent generosity to manipulate Horace into helping her commit the real theft.

“You’ll be arrested for stealing the jewels.”

Significance: The deception ultimately turns Horace into the person whose fingerprints identify him as the burglar.

“Horace Danby was in prison.”

Significance: The ending shows the consequence of trusting appearances and committing crime in the first place.

5. Complete NCERT Textbook Solutions

A. Read and Find Out — Page 20

Q. What does Horace Danby like to collect?

Answer: He likes to collect rare and expensive books.

Q. Why does he steal every year?

Answer: He steals once a year to obtain enough money to support his collection of rare books. He carefully plans each burglary and secretly buys books through an agent.

B. Read and Find Out — Page 22

Q. Who is speaking to Horace Danby?

Answer: A young woman dressed in red is speaking to Horace. She pretends to be a member of the family living at Shotover Grange.

Q. Who is the real culprit in the story?

Answer: The real culprit is the young woman who deceives Horace, gets him to open the safe and takes the jewels. Horace is later arrested because his fingerprints are on the safe.

C. Think About It

Q. Did you begin to suspect that the lady was not the person Horace took her to be?

Answer: Yes. Her calmness in the presence of a burglar, her willingness to let him open the safe, and her claim that she had forgotten the safe combination can make a careful reader suspicious. These details suggest that she has her own plan.

Q. What subtle ways does the lady use to deceive Horace? Why does he not suspect her?

Answer: She behaves as though she knows the house, speaks confidently, interacts naturally with the dog and gives practical instructions. Horace is already inside as a burglar and therefore has little reason to question someone who appears to be a family member. His desire to escape also makes him accept her story.

Q. Why is the description of Horace as good and respectable—but not completely honest—apt?

Answer: Horace has a regular business, helpers and a respectable public life, and he does not steal for luxury or daily survival. However, he deliberately commits burglary every year. Thus he has respectable qualities but is still a criminal.

Q. Horace is a meticulous planner but still falters. Where does he go wrong and why?

Answer: He removes his gloves to open the safe after being persuaded by the woman. He also trusts her identity without verification. His desire to escape and his confidence in his own planning make him careless at the crucial moment.

D. Talk About It — Model Answers

Q. Do you think Horace Danby was unfairly punished, or did he deserve what he got?

Answer: Horace's punishment follows from his deliberate choice to commit burglary. Although he is also deceived by another thief, he was himself breaking the law. His story illustrates that criminal actions can have consequences even when a person sees himself as respectable.

Q. Do intentions justify actions? Would you do something wrong if you thought your ends justified the means?

Answer: Good intentions do not automatically make a wrong action right. Horace steals to buy books, a harmless hobby, but the method is still criminal. A better approach is to pursue legitimate means even when the desired goal is valuable.

Q. Are there situations in which it is excusable to act less than honestly?

Answer: Honesty is generally essential for trust and social cooperation. Some difficult situations may involve competing moral duties, but deliberate deception should not be treated casually as acceptable simply because it offers convenience or personal benefit.

6. Extract-Based Questions

“Everyone thought that Horace Danby was a good, honest citizen... but not completely honest.”

1. What contradiction is presented?

Answer: His respectable public image contrasts with his criminal secret.

2. What is Horace’s profession?

Answer: He makes locks.

3. Why does he steal?

Answer: To finance his collection of rare books.

4. Why is the description significant?

Answer: It prepares the reader for the moral contradiction at the heart of the story.

“I came back just in time, though I didn’t expect to meet a burglar.”

1. Who says this?

Answer: The young woman.

2. What does she pretend to be?

Answer: A member of the family / lady of the house.

3. Why does Horace believe her?

Answer: She behaves confidently and appears familiar with the house.

4. What is she actually doing?

Answer: She is another thief manipulating Horace into opening the safe.

“You’ll be arrested for stealing the jewels.”

1. Why is Horace vulnerable to this threat?

Answer: He knows he was committing burglary and fears the police.

2. Who has actually stolen the jewels?

Answer: The young woman.

3. What evidence links Horace to the crime?

Answer: His fingerprints on the safe.

4. What is the result?

Answer: He is arrested and sent to prison.

7. Very Short Answer Questions

Q. What is Horace’s profession?

Answer: He is a locksmith.

Q. What does Horace collect?

Answer: Rare and expensive books.

Q. How often does he steal?

Answer: Once a year.

Q. Where does he plan to steal from?

Answer: Shotover Grange.

Q. What condition does he suffer from?

Answer: Hay fever.

Q. Who is Sherry?

Answer: The dog at the house.

Q. What does Horace use to open the safe?

Answer: His knowledge and tools as a locksmith.

Q. Who deceives Horace?

Answer: A young female thief posing as the lady of the house.

Q. What identifies Horace to the police?

Answer: His fingerprints on the safe.

Q. Where does Horace end up?

Answer: In prison.

8. Short Answer Questions

Q. Why did Horace steal only once a year?

Answer: He did not steal for daily survival. He planned one carefully organised burglary each year, taking enough money to support himself and buy rare books for the following year.

Q. Why was Horace confident about the Shotover Grange burglary?

Answer: He had studied the house, knew the location of the safe and had carefully prepared his tools and escape plan. His previous burglaries had also been successful.

Q. Why does Horace trust the young woman?

Answer: She appears confident, behaves as if she belongs to the house, speaks naturally about its details and even has a dog respond to her. Horace is also under pressure and wants to avoid being caught.

Q. How does the woman use Horace's situation against him?

Answer: She knows that Horace cannot call the police without exposing himself. She therefore offers him apparent safety in exchange for opening the safe, turning his fear of arrest into a tool for manipulating him.

Q. What is ironic about Horace being a locksmith?

Answer: He is an expert with locks and carefully plans burglaries, yet he is defeated because he fails to recognise a person's deception and leaves fingerprints that provide evidence against him.

9. Long Answer Questions

Q. Describe Horace Danby as a character.

Answer: Horace is a fifty-year-old locksmith who appears respectable and has a successful business. He is intelligent, methodical and extremely careful when planning his annual burglary. His motive is unusual: he wants money to buy rare books. Nevertheless, he deliberately breaks the law. His greatest weakness is overconfidence. He believes he can judge the situation correctly but trusts a stranger who pretends to be the lady of the house. He is finally arrested because his fingerprints are left on the safe.

Q. How does the young woman outsmart Horace Danby?

Answer: The woman remains calm when she encounters Horace and pretends to be a member of the family. She knows enough about the house to make her identity convincing and uses the fact that Horace fears the police. She tells him that she has forgotten the safe combination and persuades him to open it. Horace removes his gloves and opens the safe for her. She takes the jewels and leaves him to face the consequences.

Q. Explain the significance of the title 'A Question of Trust'.

Answer: Trust is central to the story because Horace trusts the young woman's false identity while she exploits his confidence. At the same time, Horace himself is not worthy of complete trust because he is a burglar despite his respectable public image. The story shows that appearances can be deceptive and that misplaced trust can have serious consequences.

10. Value-Based Questions

Q. What lesson does the story teach about judging people by appearances?

Answer: A respectable appearance does not guarantee honesty, and an apparently harmless person may be deceptive. People should therefore use sound judgement rather than relying only on appearances.

Q. Why should personal goals not be pursued through dishonest means?

Answer: A good goal does not erase the harm caused by dishonest methods. Horace's love of books is admirable, but burglary leads to legal and personal consequences.

Q. What can students learn about overconfidence?

Answer: Skill and careful planning are useful, but overconfidence can create blind spots. Horace's confidence prevents him from questioning the woman's identity.

11. Additional Important Questions

Q. Why did Horace wear gloves?

Answer: To avoid leaving fingerprints while committing the burglary.

Q. Why did he remove his gloves?

Answer: The woman persuaded him that she was the owner and needed him to open the safe; he removed them to work with the lock more easily.

Q. Why is the woman's behaviour suspicious?

Answer: She is unusually calm, knows details of the house and encourages a burglar to open the safe rather than immediately calling the police.

Q. What is the role of Sherry?

Answer: The dog's familiarity with the woman helps support her false appearance as a member of the household.

Q. What is the final irony?

Answer: A thief is deceived by another thief, and the careful burglar is arrested because he trusts the wrong person.

12. CBSE Exam-Oriented Questions

Q. Competency-based: Horace is skilled at locks but poor at judging people. What does this suggest about expertise?

Answer: Expertise in one area does not guarantee sound judgement in every situation. Horace's technical skill cannot protect him from psychological deception.

Q. Case-based: A person appears respectable but secretly breaks rules. How should others assess such a person?

Answer: Assessment should be based on consistent actions and evidence rather than appearance alone. Respectability should not be confused with complete honesty.

Q. Analytical: 'The story proves that a criminal can also become the victim of another criminal.' Discuss.

Answer: Horace is himself a burglar, but the young woman is also a thief who manipulates him. His criminal intention makes him vulnerable because he cannot safely seek help from the police.

13. MCQs

1. Horace Danby is a:
A. teacher B. locksmith C. doctor D. writer
2. Horace collects:
A. paintings B. coins C. rare books D. stamps
3. Horace steals:
A. monthly B. weekly C. yearly D. daily
4. The burglary takes place at:
A. Shotover Grange B. Iping C. a hotel D. a shop
5. Horace suffers from:
A. asthma B. hay fever C. fever D. lumbago
6. The woman pretends to be:
A. a police officer B. the lady of the house C. a servant D. a neighbour
7. Sherry is a:
A. horse B. cat C. dog D. parrot
8. Horace is finally caught because of his:
A. tools B. fingerprints C. books D. car
9. The woman's real identity is:
A. owner B. thief C. police officer D. servant
10. The main twist depends on:
A. friendship B. misplaced trust C. science D. travel

MCQ Answer Key

1-B, 2-C, 3-C, 4-A, 5-B, 6-B, 7-C, 8-B, 9-B, 10-B

14. Teacher's Note on Answer Writing

2-3 marks: Answer directly and include the key reason/event.

5-6 marks: Use a clear opening, 3-4 developed points and a concluding inference.

Extracts: Identify context/speaker first, then answer precisely.